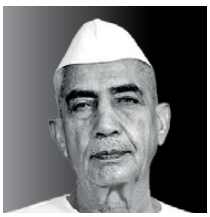
PRIME MOVERS



Indira Gandhi
1966–77; 1980–84



Morarji Desai
1977–79



Charan Singh
1979–80



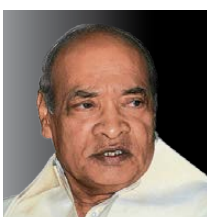
Rajiv Gandhi
1984–89



V.P. Singh
1989–90



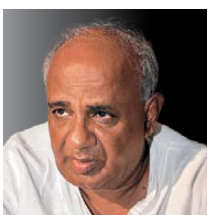
Chandra Shekhar
1990–91



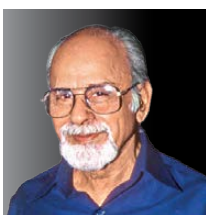
P.V. Narasimha Rao
1991–96



A.B. Vajpayee
1996; 1998–2004



H.D. Deve Gowda
1996–97



I.K. Gujral
1997–98



Manmohan Singh
2004–14



Narendra Modi
2014–

sion and computers. A younger India was becoming visible. Rajiv Gandhi, who at 40 became the youngest prime minister in Indian history, embodied that moment with his boyish good looks, an unprecedented majority, and a leaning towards computers and telecommunications. Technology as an instrument of empowerment, not privilege. But his aspirations ran ahead of political skill, and his tenure became a study in promise constrained by mis-steps and scandal. But Indian democracy was to deepen and acquire more colours. V.P. Singh's Mandal manoeuvre transformed politics by drawing historically marginalised communities into the centre of power. The social upheaval was intense, even violent, but the Republic emerged more representative, with OBC leaders such as Mulayam Singh Yadav in UP and Lalu Prasad Yadav in Bihar coming to the fore. At the same time, the counter movement around Ram Janmabhoomi, led by Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) stalwart L.K. Advani and backed by the Sangh Parivar, altered electoral alignments around religion, redefined identity and exposed the deep fractures in Indian society, especially after the demolition of the Babri Masjid in 1992.

But before that came India's most consequential economic pivot. In 1991, facing near-bankruptcy, the country abandoned decades of state control and chose reform. P.V. Narasimha Rao, a quiet, scholarly prime minister running a minority government, presided over a revolution disguised as pragmatism. Along with his erudite finance minister Manmohan Singh, he dismantled the Licence Raj, opened India to global markets, devalued the rupee, and freed enterprise from suffocating controls. A nation raised on Nehruvian socialism surged toward liberalisation. Rao's political subtlety kept fragile coalitions intact while the economy was being fundamentally rewired. The late 1990s reflected the aftershocks of this transformation. Politics fragmented as coalitions became the norm and regional leaders assumed national relevance. Governance demanded negotiation rather than command. From this churn emerged an unexpected steady hand. Atal Bihari Vajpayee, whose eloquence itself became governance, brought stability without authoritarianism. Under him, India conducted nuclear tests, fought the Kargil war, pursued infrastructure expansion and cautiously engaged with Pakistan. He demonstrated that firmness could coexist with civility, that leadership need not be abrasive to be effective. Socially, the pace of change, too, accelerated. The internet collapsed distances. Mobile phones reshaped communication. Migration, consumption and cultural exchange altered how Indians imagined opportunity. From a fortnightly, INDIA